

Detailed Visa Application Process from the USA

This is a digital process managed through Colombia's Ministry of Foreign Affairs (Cancillería) portal. The principal applicant (you) applies first, and then your family members apply as your beneficiaries.

Timeline: Start this immediately. The entire process, from gathering documents to visa approval, typically takes 4 to 6 weeks, but can be longer if documents need corrections.

Required Government Fees (Paid Directly to Colombia):

Complete Total for Everyone (You + Your Family of 3)

Person	Study Fee	Issuance Fee	ID Card	Grand Total
You	\$65	\$271	\$61	\$397
Your Wife	\$54	\$270	\$61	\$385
Child 1	\$54	\$270	\$61	\$385
Child 2	\$54	\$270	\$61	\$385
FAMILY GRAND TOTAL	\$227	\$1,081	\$244	\$1,552



For You (Principal Applicant - Retired)

As the primary visa holder, you must prove that you receive a lifetime pension.

Needed Visa Documents

Details & How to Get It from the USA

1. Valid U.S. Passport

A digital copy of the information page. Must be valid for at least 6 months beyond your planned entry date and have at least 2 blank pages.

2. Passport Photo

A recent digital photo, 3x4 cm, with a white background, facing forward, without glasses or accessories

3. Proof of Pension

The Social Security Benefit Verification Letter (or a letter from your private pension provider). It must show you receive a lifetime monthly pension equal to or greater than 3 SMLMV.

The 2026 minimum is COP 5,252,715 (approx. \$1,427 USD).

The exchange rate fluctuates, so check the current rate before applying.

4. FBI Background Check

You must request an FBI Identity History Summary Check from the U.S. Department of Justice. This is a stricter requirement than a state-level check.

5. FBI background check/ Apostille

The U.S. Department of State in Washington, D.C., must issue an Apostille for your FBI background check. State-level apostilles are not accepted for this federal document.

6. Official Spanish Translation

All documents not originally in Spanish (your pension letter, FBI report, marriage/birth certificates) must be translated by a Colombian-certified official translator (traductor oficial).

7. Medical Certificate	<i>A general health exam certificate (physical) issued by a registered doctor.</i> While it can be obtained from a doctor in the U.S., many retirees find it easier to obtain it from a Colombian clinic after they arrive.
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8. Travel Health Insurance	<i>You must have comprehensive "All-Risk" health insurance that is valid in Colombia for the entire duration of your visa.</i> The policy must cover you against all risks, including repatriation. International plans like Cigna Global or GeoBlue are common choices.
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 For Your Wife and Two Children (Beneficiaries)

Their visas are dependent on yours. You will apply for them after your principal visa is approved.

Needed Visa Documents

Details for Each Family Member

1. Valid Passport	A digital copy of the information page from each family member's valid U.S. passport.
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2. Passport Photo	A recent digital passport-style photo (same 3x4 cm specs) for each person.
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3. Proof of Relationship	<i>For your wife:</i> An apostilled and officially translated copy of your Marriage Certificate. <i>For your children:</i> An apostilled and officially translated copy of each child's Birth Certificate listing both parents. Note: These documents must first be apostilled by the U.S. state that issued them (e.g., the Secretary of State of the state <i>where you were married or where your children were born</i>).
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4. Dependency Letter

A formal letter, signed by you, in which you declare that each family member is economically dependent on you and that you take full responsibility for their stay and departure from Colombia. For minor children, both parents must generally sign.

5. Copy of Your Valid Visa

A digital copy of your approved M-11 Pensionado Visa. This is essential, as their applications are linked to your active visa status.

Best International Health Insurance for Your Visa

Even if you have military medical benefits from your home country, you must apply for international health insurance to apply for a visa in most countries.

1. SafetyWing

Overview: SafetyWing is popular among digital nomads and remote workers. It offers affordable, flexible plans designed for long-term travelers.

Cost: Starts at around \$45–50 per month for basic coverage.

Website: <https://www.safetywing.com>

2. World Nomads

Overview: World Nomads is tailored for travelers and digital nomads. It offers customizable plans with varying levels of coverage.

Cost: Plans start at around \$50–70 per month for basic coverage.

Website: <https://www.worldnomads.com>

3. IMG Global

Overview: IMG offers a range of international health insurance plans, including budget-friendly options for travelers and expats.

Cost: Some plans start at around \$60–75 per month for basic coverage.

Website: <https://www.imglobal.com>

4. Insured Nomads

Overview: Insured Nomads offers health insurance tailored to digital nomads and remote workers, with flexible plans.

Cost: Plans start at around \$50–70 per month for basic coverage.

Website: <https://www.imglobal.com>

5. Cigna Global

Overview: Cigna offers comprehensive international health insurance plans, but their basic plans may fit your budget.

Cost: Basic plans start at around \$70–100 per month (may exceed your budget, but worth checking for discounts).

Website: <https://www.cignaglobal.com>

6. HTH Worldwide

Overview: HTH offers international health insurance plans for travelers and expats, with some affordable options.

Cost: Plans start at around \$60–80 per month for basic coverage.

Website: <https://www.hthtravelinsurance.com>

7. AXA – Global Healthcare

Overview: AXA offers international health insurance with customizable plans, including budget-friendly options.

Cost: Basic plans start at around \$70–90 per month.

Website: <https://www.axa.com>

Tips for Choosing a Plan:

1. **Check Visa Requirements:** Ensure the plan meets the specific health insurance requirements for the digital nomad visas you're applying for.
2. **Coverage Limits:** Look at the coverage limits, exclusions, and deductibles to ensure the plan provides adequate protection.

3. **Geographic Coverage:** Confirm that the plan covers all the countries you plan to visit or reside in.
 4. **Pre-Existing Conditions:** Check whether any pre-existing conditions are covered or excluded.
 5. **Customer Reviews:** Read reviews to ensure the provider has good customer service and claims processing.
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If your budget is strict, **SafetyWing** or **World Nomads** are likely your best options. However, if you can stretch your budget slightly, you may find more comprehensive coverage with providers like **IMG Global** or **Cigna Global**. Always compare multiple quotes to find the best fit for your needs.

Your Correct Application Sequence

1. Apply for your M-11 Pensionado Visa (principal applicant)
2. Wait for approval - processing typically takes 5-30 business days
3. Once YOUR visa is approved and issued, submit applications for:
 - Your wife (spouse/permanent partner)
 - Your children (under 25 years old or with permanent disability)

Questions and Answers

1. Does my wife need an Apostille Stamp on her birth certificate for a Colombian visa?

No, your wife does not need to get an apostille for her Dominican birth certificate for the Colombian Retirement Visa (Visor Pensionado) process.

Here is the specific breakdown for your family:

- **You & Your Children (U.S. Citizens):** Apostille Required. Your birth certificate and your children's birth certificates must have an Apostille to prove your relationship to the primary visa holder (you).
- **Your Wife (Dominican):** No Apostille Required for her birth certificate. Colombia treats her as your "beneficiary" (spouse). While foreign documents generally require an apostille, *Colombia has a specific bilateral agreement with the Dominican Republic that simplifies the process.*
- **Your Marriage Certificate (U.S. or Dominican):** Apostille Required. Regardless of where you were married, you must have this document legalized. If you have a U.S. marriage certificate, it must have the Apostille and be officially translated into Spanish to prove your family tie.

Step 1: Get a Certified Copy

Order a certified copy of your marriage certificate from the state or county vital records office where you married. A photocopy will not be accepted.

Step 2: Submit to the Correct State Authority

Find your state's apostille office below:

State

Agency

Official Link

Florida

Secretary of State

[Florida Apostille](#)

Texas

Secretary of State

[Texas Apostille](#)

New York

Department of State

[New York Apostille](#)

California

Secretary of State

[California Apostille](#)

All other states

Secretary of State

[Full list of all states](#)



Submission Options

- By mail – available in all states
- In person – available in many states (check your state's page)
- By appointment – Texas offers appointments on Tuesdays and Fridays



Step 3: Get a Sworn Spanish Translation

Once you receive the apostilled document, hire a Colombian Sworn Translator (*Traductor Oficial*) authorized by Colombia's Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

2. Where do I go in my city to get an FBI background check on myself?

Official FBI Links

Link Type	URL
FBI CJIS Division Main Page	https://www.fbi.gov/services/cjis/identity-history-summary-checks
FBI FAQs (Detailed Instructions)	https://www.fbi.gov/how-we-can-help-you/more-fbi-services-and-information/identity-history-summary-checks/identity-history-summary-checks-faqs
FBI-Approved Channelers List	https://www.fbi.gov/services/cjis/identity-history-summary-checks/fbi-approved-channelers

FBI Contact Information

Contact Method	Information
Phone	304-625-5590
Email	identity@fbi.gov

Mailing Address	FBI CJIS Division, 1000 Custer Hollow Road, Clarksburg, WV 26306
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Quick Steps to Start

1. Go to the FBI CJIS Division page (first link above)
2. Click through to the electronic submission portal
3. Complete the online application and pay the \$18 fee
4. Get fingerprinted (either at a channeler, USPS, or via paper card)

For channeler pricing, refer to the three companies provided in the previous response (Fieldprint, Accurate Biometrics, IDEMIA) - they are the fastest option for getting results.

Here are three FBI-approved channelers you can use to get your background check:

1. Fieldprint

Fieldprint is an FBI-approved channeler that processes digital fingerprints and transmits them electronically to the FBI.

Detail	Information
Phone Number	800-369-2612 (ext. 2222 for customer service)
Website	www.fieldprint.com
Cost	Varies by location and service type; typically \$50–75 plus the FBI's \$18 fee. You'll see the exact cost when registering.

2. Accurate Biometrics

Accurate Biometrics has been an FBI-approved channeler since 2006, offering Live Scan fingerprinting services nationwide.

Detail	Information
Phone Number	866-361-9944 or 773-685-5832 (Account Management)
Website	www.accuratebiometrics.com
Cost	Typically \$50–65 plus the FBI's \$18 fee (varies by location). Contact them directly for exact pricing.

3. IDEMIA (IdentoGo)

IDEMIA (formerly MorphoTrust) operates thousands of IdentoGo fingerprinting locations across the United States and is contracted by multiple state governments.

Detail	Information
Phone Number	844-321-2101 (toll-free)
Website	www.identogo.com
Cost	Varies by state. Examples: Pennsylvania charges \$101.25 total (includes FBI, state, and IDEMIA fees). You'll see the exact cost when registering.

How the Process Works

Once you choose a channeler, you will:

1. Register online or by phone through their website
 2. Schedule an appointment at a nearby location (they have hundreds of sites nationwide)
 3. Bring a valid photo ID (driver's license or passport) to your appointment
 4. Get fingerprinted (digital "Live Scan" - no ink)
 5. Receive results typically within 24-72 hours as a PDF.
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Important Note for Your Move to Colombia

After receiving your FBI background check results, you must:

1. Get the report apostilled by the U.S. Department of State (not just a state-level apostille)
2. Hire a Colombian sworn translator to translate it into Spanish for your visa application

3. Do I need to complete the Colombian Visa application in Spanish?

No, you do not need to fill out the Colombian visa application form in Spanish. You can complete it in either English or Spanish.

Here are the specific language requirements for each part of the process:

Application Component	Language Requirement
Online Visa Application Form	English or Spanish
Your Supporting Documents (birth certificates, marriage certificate, FBI background check, bank statements, etc.)	English or Spanish
Documents NOT in English or Spanish	Must be translated by a Colombian Sworn Translator (<i>Traductor Oficial</i>), and the translation must be apostilled or legalized.

Important Notes About Translation

1. Bank Statements: These are an exception. If the visa officer can clearly understand the content, you may not need a translation.

2. Who Can Translate: If you need a translation, it must be done by an official translator certified by recognized Colombian entities, such as:
 - Universidad Nacional de Colombia
 - Universidad de Antioquia
 - Colombian Ministry of Justice (for certifications issued before 1999)
 3. What Happens After Translation: Once translated, the translation must also be apostilled or legalized, just like the original document.
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Practical Recommendation

Since you and your children have U.S. documents (birth certificates, marriage certificates, and FBI background checks) that will need official Spanish translations, your best approach is to:

1. Complete the online application in English (easier for you)
2. Get all your U.S. documents apostilled first
3. Hire a Colombian sworn translator to translate all apostilled documents into Spanish
4. Submit everything through the Colombian visa system

4. Step-by-step instructions to get your visa approved at the Colombian Consulate.

Before Applying (Gather Your Documents)

1. Collect your apostilled pension certificate, apostilled birth and marriage certificates, and apostilled FBI background check.
2. Get all apostilled documents translated into Spanish by a Colombian government-authorized translator.
3. Purchase international health insurance valid for at least 1 year with coverage in Colombia.
4. Please obtain a medical certificate confirming that you are in good physical and mental health.
5. Scan the main page of your passport and have a digital 3x4 cm photo ready.

Step 1: Complete the Online Application Form

6. Go to the Colombian Ministry of Foreign Affairs visa application site.
7. Fill out Form DP-FO-67 "Application for a visa" completely and accurately.
8. Upload all scanned documents (PDF format) and your digital photo (JPG format).
9. Pay the USD \$50 visa study fee online.

Step 2: Wait for the Consulate's Instructions

10. Check your email regularly for messages from the visa system.
11. Some applications are fully online, while others require you to submit your passport to the consulate for a visa sticker.
12. Follow the instructions exactly as they appear in your approval email.

Step 3: Pay and Receive Your Visa

13. Once approved, pay the USD \$175 visa issuance fee online.
14. Receive your approved visa via email.
15. Print the visa approval and keep it with your passport for travel.

Step 4: Enter Colombia and Get Your ID Card

16. Travel to Colombia within the validity period stated on your visa.
17. Upon arrival, the immigration officer will stamp your passport with an entry permit.
- 18. Within 15 days of arrival, apply for your Foreigner ID Card (Cédula de Extranjería) at a Migración Colombia office.**
19. Your spouse and children can now apply for their Beneficiary Visas from within Colombia.

Important Reminders

- Start your application at least 1 month before your planned travel date.
- All foreign documents must be apostilled and translated before submitting.
- Your monthly pension must be at least 3 Colombian minimum wages (approximately USD \$1,400 per month in 2025).

5. Documents That Must Be Apostilled & Translated

You must get an apostille for any document issued by a foreign authority (outside of Colombia). Once apostilled, these documents also require an official Spanish translation.

The following documents DO require an apostille:

- **Pension Certificate:** The official document from your pension provider must be **apostilled and translated**. It must show the monthly amount (at least 3 Colombian minimum wages, approx. \$1,400 USD/month in 2025) and confirm that the pension is permanent (lifetime).
- **Criminal Record / Background Check:** The FBI background check you mentioned must be **apostilled and translated**. Ensure it was issued within the last 3-6 months.
- **Birth Certificate (for you and your children):** These civil registry documents must be **apostilled and translated**.
- **Marriage Certificate:** To prove your relationship with your wife, this must be **apostilled and translated**.

Documents That DO NOT Require an Apostille

Colombian regulations recognize that the following documents are generally acceptable without an apostille:

- **Bank Statements:** If you are presenting statements to prove financial solvency, they can be submitted without an apostille or translation, provided the visa officer can clearly read and understand them.
- **Passport:** Your valid passport and a copy of the biographical data page do not require an apostille.
- **Photographs:** The standard 3x4 cm color photos do not require legalization.

 Summary Table for Quick Reference

Document	Apostille Required?	Translation Required?
Pension Certificate	Yes	Yes (Official Spanish)
FBI/Criminal Record	Yes	Yes (Official Spanish)
Birth Certificates	Yes	Yes (Official Spanish)
Marriage Certificate	Yes	Yes (Official Spanish)
Bank Statements	No	No
Passport	No	No

Important Note: All apostilled documents must be issued within three months of your visa application date

6. What are the Monthly Economic Calculations for my Visa?

Based on the official requirements from the Colombian Ministry of Foreign Affairs and immigration resources, ***you are only required to submit your personal retirement calculations to qualify for the visa.*** Your family's income is not required.

Here is the detailed breakdown of why you only need to submit your own financial proof:

- **Sole Responsibility:** The financial requirement is the primary applicant's (you) responsibility. The law states that the foreigner applying for the visa must receive a pension of a specific amount.
- **Dependents are Beneficiaries:** Your wife and children apply as your beneficiaries (*beneficiarios*). Their role is to be economically dependent on you, not to contribute their own income to meet the visa threshold.
- **The Income Threshold (2025/2026):** You must prove a monthly pension income equivalent to at least three (3) Current Legal Monthly Minimum Wages (SMMLV). **In 2026, this is roughly 1,000–1,400 USD per month**, though this fluctuates with the exchange rate and annual minimum wage increases.

7. Can my family live/ leave for 6 months and visit our family in another country?

The short answer is yes, you can leave for up to 6 months at a time, but you must return to Colombia at least once every 6 months to keep your visa active.

Here is the specific rule for your Migrant (M) Retirement Visa:

- **Absence Limit:** You cannot stay outside Colombia for more than six (6) consecutive months.
- **Re-entry Requirement:** To maintain your visa status, you must physically re-enter Colombia at least 1 day before reaching the 6-month mark. You can leave again immediately after, but you must reset the clock.
- **Consequence of Overstaying:** If you stay abroad for more than 6 consecutive months, your Migrant Visa expires automatically.

How This Affects Your Plan to Visit Family

Based on your plan to visit family for 6 months, here is how the rule applies to you:

- **Strict Limit:** 6 months is the exact maximum limit.
- **A One-Day Buffer:** To be safe, we recommend returning before the 6-month mark (e.g., at 5 months and 3 weeks) rather than exactly on the last day, to account for any flight delays or immigration processing issues.

Does This Apply to Your Wife and Children?

Yes. As beneficiaries on your visa (holding Migrant Visas as your spouse and dependents), your wife and children are subject to the same 6-month absence rule.

8. Step-by-Step Process to Get Your Cédula de Extranjería

Step 1: Enter Colombia With Your Approved Visa

- **Your visa is electronic (E-Visa) and arrives via email.** Visas are no longer stamped in passports. Enter Colombia using this approved visa.

Step 2: Book Your Appointment Online (Before You Go)

You must request an appointment through Migración Colombia's official online portal:

 <https://migracioncolombia.odoo.com/en>

Insider Tip: Appointments for the following week are typically released on Sundays at 5:00 PM Colombia time.

Step 3: Complete the Unified Application Form (FUT)

- Before your appointment, complete the Formulario Único de Trámite (FUT) on the Migración Colombia website.

Step 4: Pay the Official Fee

- **Cost: Approximately \$61 USD (COP 294,000 as of 2026) per person.**
- How to pay: Online or at authorized banks. Keep your payment receipt.

Step 5: Gather Your Required Documents

Bring the originals (and photocopies) of the following to your appointment :

Document	Details
Valid Passport	Your original passport
Visa Copy	Printout of your approved E-Visa
FUT Form	Completed and printed

Payment Receipt

Proof you paid the ID card fee

Step 6: Attend Your Appointment at a Migración Colombia Office

- Go to the nearest Migration Services Facilitator Center (CFSM) - this is the Migración Colombia regional office for your area.
- Complete biometric capture: photo, fingerprints, and electronic signature.

Step 7: Wait for Your Card to Be Ready

- Standard delivery time: 3 business days after payment.
- Check online at the Migración Colombia portal to see when your card is ready for pickup.

Step 8: Pick Up Your Cédula de Extranjería

- Return to the same CFSM office where you applied.
 - Your physical Cédula de Extranjería is now in your hands.
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Where to Go in Cali (Near Chipichape Mall)

The nearest Migración Colombia office to Chipichape Mall is:

Office Name	Address	Approx. Distance from Chipichape
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Migración Colombia - Cali (Sede Norte)	Calle 25N # 4N - 70, Barrio El Bosque, Cali	~10-15 minutes by car
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To confirm the exact address, opening hours, and schedule your appointment, check the official regional office section on the Migración Colombia website:

 <https://www.migracioncolombia.gov.co/regional>

Additional Suggestions for a Smooth Relocation

Beyond the core steps in the plan, here are some other key considerations for your move:

- **Healthcare is a Top Priority:** Colombia has an excellent healthcare system. Registering with a private health insurer (EPS) is a critical step for your family. A monthly plan for a family is estimated to cost between €45 and €185. The Fundación Valle del Lili in Cali is recognized as one of the best hospitals in Latin America.
- **Education Planning:** If your children are school-aged, start researching international or bilingual schools in Cali. These are the most common choices for expat families, and their application processes should be started well before your move.
- **Rent Before You Buy:** The universal advice from expats in Cali is to rent for at least 6-12 months before even considering buying a property. This allows you to truly understand the different neighborhoods and the local real estate market.
- **The 4x1000 Tax:** Be aware of Colombia's "4x1000" tax, a small levy on every financial transaction. While it can be a minor annoyance, some banks offer ways to minimize or return this tax for account holders.

9. 🏢 Agencies/Attorneys for English Speakers Apply for Visas

Using a reputable agency is highly recommended. They handle the document review, official translations, and direct communication with the Cancillería, preventing costly errors and delays.

Agency Name	Key Features	Contact Information
Colombian Passport	Highly recommended by expats. Run by lead attorney Camila Ocampo. Focuses on "elite strategy" and handles everything from document review to submission. They specialize in the M-11 Pensionado Visa for U.S. citizens.	Website: https://www.colombianpassport.com/ Phone: +57 318 382 4185
Expat Group	A long-established (12+ years), interdisciplinary team that assists not only with visas but also with housing, investment, and other relocation needs. They offer specific services for obtaining U.S. FBI background checks from Colombia.	Website: https://expatgroup.co/ Phone: +57 604 322 1349
Nexo Legal	A modern law firm that provides clear, updated legal advice for 2026 visa requirements. They offer personalized consultations to determine the best visa strategy for your family and can manage the entire application process.	Website: https://nexo.legal/ Phone: +57 314 687 2108

📋 Checklist: Your Immediate Next Steps

1. **Start Document Collection:** Request your Social Security Benefit Verification Letter and begin the FBI Background Check process immediately, as the Apostille from Washington, D.C., can take several weeks.
2. **Contact an Agency:** Reach out to one of the three agencies listed above for a consultation. They will confirm the current minimum income requirement (based on the daily exchange rate) and provide a final checklist of documents tailored to your family.
3. **Secure Health Insurance:** Get quotes for an "All-Risk" international health insurance plan that explicitly states it is valid for long-term residency in Colombia.